Enterprise Agents and the Frontier Labs

What enterprises and the frontier labs are doing in AI agents that finish enterprise work, and which budget pays for that work

1. Key takeaways

The theme covers AI agents that finish a defined piece of enterprise work, such as working a denied medical claim or clearing a purchase order exception, and the software that runs them. Enterprises are adopting these agents quickly, while OpenAI, Anthropic, Microsoft and Google are moving from selling models toward selling the agents and the deployment work themselves.

1. **Agents that finish work get paid from labor and services budgets, which are many times bigger than software budgets and are increasingly controlled by business owners rather than IT**
   - Companies spend far more paying people and outsourcers to do their work than buying the software those people use. Sequoia estimates that six dollars go to services for every dollar spent on software (Sequoia), Felicis puts labor budgets at 35 times software budgets (Felicis), and US government data counts 17,753,430 office and administrative support workers earning a mean wage of $51,560 (BLS).
   - Outsourcing contracts are the first part of that spending to be repriced, because agents can take over work that outsourcers bill by the hour or by the head. HFS expects agent-delivered services to become a $422 billion segment inside the outsourcing market by 2035 (HFS Research), and a contact center outsourcing executive says agents are moving the industry's billing from a price per worker to a price per use (expert call).
   - Decisions about AI spending have moved out of IT and into the business units that run the work, where an agent is weighed against an outsourcer's invoice. BCG finds that AI spending doubled in a year to 3.3% of revenue and that more than 80% of it now sits outside the enterprise IT budget (BCG), and Sequoia argues that replacing an outsourcing contract with an AI provider is a simple change of vendor, while replacing headcount means reorganizing the company (Sequoia).
2. **Almost every big enterprise now runs agents, but few can show a return yet, and buyers still pay for AI mostly by the seat or by usage**
   - Agent use has spread across big companies quickly, both in surveys of enterprises and in the agent counts the main platforms report. In a July 2026 survey 95.3% of enterprises ran at least one agent workflow in production (IDC), and Microsoft counts over 50M agents in its registry, up more than 30% in a quarter (Microsoft earnings call).
   - Returns lag well behind that usage, because most agents that enterprises have built still do simple, narrow and mostly supervised tasks. Only 13% of CIOs report significant or transformational value from AI (Gartner), only 22% of organizations have scaled AI across multiple business units (Gartner), and the head of Amazon Web Services describes most enterprise agents as relatively simple and mostly non-autonomous (AWS interview).
   - With returns still unproven, buyers distrust savings claims and keep paying the way they always have. For AI features billed separately, decision makers rank per-seat pricing first at 42.3%, ahead of consumption at 36.6% and outcome pricing at 21.1% (Futurum), ServiceNow's finance chief says its customers are not asking for outcome pricing at all (ServiceNow earnings call), and a revenue cycle executive whose own gains are in the low double digits dismisses any vendor claim above that (expert call).
3. **Since January the labs have moved from selling models to selling the agent runtime, ready-made department agents and their own deployment services, backed by fast-growing enterprise revenue**
   - Businesses now account for most of the revenue at both Anthropic and OpenAI, and that revenue is growing fast. Anthropic reported revenue of $16.29 billion for the first half of 2026, up from $1.16 billion a year earlier, with most of it coming from businesses paying per use (Reuters), and OpenAI's finance chief

told investors in August that enterprise now brings in more revenue than consumers (Unite.AI), with annualized revenue of roughly $50 billion at the end of September (Bloomberg).

- The software that runs agents, which agent platforms used to sell on its own, now comes from the labs at close to the cost of the tokens it uses. Anthropic launched Managed Agents at $0.08 per session-hour in April (Anthropic), and OpenAI opened its Agents API in September with no fees beyond tokens and tools (OpenAI).
- On top of that runtime both labs ship ready-made agents for whole departments that take a goal through to finished documents and analyses. Anthropic open-sourced 11 Cowork plugins for roles from sales and finance to legal and customer support in January (Anthropic), and OpenAI launched ChatGPT Work in July as an agent that turns a goal into finished work (OpenAI).
- To get those agents into production the labs are adding people and acquisitions as well as products. OpenAI formed a majority-owned deployment company with more than $4B of initial investment (OpenAI), Anthropic formed a services firm with Blackstone, Hellman & Friedman and Goldman Sachs aimed at mid-sized companies (Anthropic), and OpenAI's Frontier Alliances bring in BCG, McKinsey, Accenture and Capgemini to deploy its platform (OpenAI). Through September 29 AI companies funded by venture investors bought 195 other AI companies, with OpenAI making 10 of those deals and Anthropic 5 (Crunchbase via Forbes).
- Buyers are hedging against any single lab by spreading their bets across models and keeping control of their own agents. In a survey 81% of big-company CIOs use three or more model families (a16z CIO survey), and 67% of agent platform users expect the control plane to sit at least partly outside a provider-managed service (VentureBeat survey).

4. **The labs ship templates and tools but leave the work that needs private data, write access to core systems, a license or liability with the buyer and its service providers**
   - Lab products stop at the template and leave the buyer responsible for the outcome, because running a regulated or messy operation is slow, local and risky work. Sapphire Ventures finds that the labs do not want to take on the operational mess of running work for customers (Sapphire Ventures).
   - Across the ten categories in Part 2, procurement, logistics and distribution is the least likely to be absorbed by the labs, followed by healthcare administration and insurance operations, where lab tools stop short of the plan's or carrier's own decisions. Work context, life sciences research and finance operations sit in the middle, while orchestration platforms, bank compliance, legal services and customer service are the most exposed, because the labs, their partners or the big software suites already sell agents straight to the teams doing that work.

2. Interesting categories

We split the theme into horizontal software that runs agents across a company, regulated verticals where a license or rulebook governs the work, and non-regulated verticals where the work is operational. In each category the lab moves are those OpenAI, Anthropic, Microsoft and Google made from January 2026 onward.

A. Horizontal

A1. Orchestration and Execution Platforms

What is happening:

- **Companies are handing agents real authority faster than they build the controls to govern them.** In a BCG survey of 1,330 executives, 42% expect agents to hold real decision authority by 2030 while only 5% have the controls in place (BCG).
- **Gartner expects most custom agent systems built by outside engineering teams to be abandoned by 2028 because they cost too much to maintain.** Gartner expects 70% of enterprises to abandon agent systems built by vendor engineering teams by 2028 because of maintenance costs (Gartner).

- **OpenAI, Google and Microsoft now each ship a generic runtime and control plane for running and governing agents.** OpenAI launched Frontier in February with HP, Oracle, State Farm, Thermo Fisher and Uber as first adopters (OpenAI), Google turned Vertex AI into the Gemini Enterprise Agent Platform in April (Google) and says nearly 90% of the Fortune 100 use Gemini Enterprise (Alphabet earnings call), and Microsoft sells Agent 365 to govern agents at $15 per user per month (Microsoft).
- **How likely the labs are to absorb this: High.** The labs and the big clouds already sell this layer to many of the biggest companies, as the Fortune 100 uptake of Gemini Enterprise shows, and the main limit on them is buyers' wish to keep their control plane at least partly outside any single provider.

Example companies: Duvo, Sycamore

A2. Work Context

What is happening:

- **Enterprises expect to tailor agents to how their own business works, which needs context that no model ships with.** In a Deloitte survey of 3,235 leaders, 85% expect to customize agents to fit the unique needs of their business (Deloitte).
- **SAP agreed to buy a company that maps how work gets done and will keep that context inside its own HR suite.** SAP says the acquired company is expected to become an intelligent core of its SuccessFactors HR software (SAP).
- **The labs now bundle company context into the agent platforms they sell to enterprises.** Frontier includes a business context layer that spans warehouses, CRM, ticketing and internal apps (OpenAI), and Anthropic lets admins package skills and connectors into private plugins for each team (Anthropic).
- **Microsoft grounds its own long-running agent in its Work IQ layer and reports wide uptake among the biggest companies.** Copilot Cowork, built with Anthropic, became generally available in June, runs on Work IQ and is used by over half of the Fortune 500 (Microsoft).
- **How likely the labs are to absorb this: Medium.** The labs and Microsoft bundle context for their own agents and SAP keeps what it buys inside its own suite, but none of the sources shows a lab selling context that spans every application and serves any model.

Example companies: Edra, Workfabric AI

B. Regulated Verticals

B1. Healthcare Administration

What is happening:

- **Federal rules now put deadlines and public reporting on prior authorization, so slow manual review becomes a visible cost for health plans.** A CMS rule requires most affected payers to decide within 72 hours for urgent requests and seven calendar days for standard ones from January 1, 2026 (CMS), and practices complete 39 prior authorization requests per physician per week (AMA).
- **On the provider side the dominant health record vendor controls which AI tools run inside big health systems, according to a revenue cycle executive.** The executive says the vendor does not allow outside AI integrations beyond its own work (expert call).
- **Both labs launched healthcare products in January, and Anthropic's includes a sample template for the prior authorization review that health plans run today.** OpenAI launched ChatGPT for Healthcare on January 8 with HCA Healthcare, Cedars-Sinai and UCSF and templates that include prior authorization support (OpenAI), and three days later Claude for Healthcare added a CMS coverage connector and a customizable prior authorization review template (Anthropic).
- **How likely the labs are to absorb this: Medium.** Both labs have named health system customers and a prior authorization template, but under the CMS rule the coverage decision and its deadline stay with the

health plan, and on the provider side the record vendor limits outside AI, according to a revenue cycle executive.

Example companies: Anterior

B2. Insurance Operations

What is happening:

- **Insurers employ big claims and policy teams whose work follows forms, rules and deadlines that agents can follow too.** Government data counts 324,230 claims adjusters, examiners and investigators at a mean wage of $80,470 (BLS), and HFS expects traditional outsourcing to "decline from 55% to 37% of delivery" within two years (HFS Research).
- **One insurance executive says agent vendors pitch the team two or three times a day and that all of the team's data stays inside the insurer's own systems.** The executive, who runs strategic partnerships at an insurance group, made both points in an August 2026 expert call (expert call).
- **Anthropic is building claims agents with Allianz, and State Farm was among the first carriers to adopt OpenAI's agent platform.** Allianz is co-developing motor and health claims agents with Anthropic (Allianz), State Farm was among the first adopters of OpenAI Frontier (OpenAI), and the listed insurtech Roadzen is launching underwriting and claims agents on Anthropic's managed agent platform (Roadzen filing).
- **How likely the labs are to absorb this: Medium.** The labs build claims agents with the biggest carriers and supply the platform that others build on, but the sources show no packaged lab insurance product, and the insurance executive in the sources keeps the team's data inside the insurer's own systems.

Example companies: Notch, Pace, Harper, Strala

B3. Lending and Financial Crime

What is happening:

- **Financial crime compliance is a big and rising cost whose biggest line is people.** It costs institutions in the US and Canada $61 billion a year, and labor is the biggest cost within that spending (LexisNexis and Forrester).
- **Capital One built its own agent platform, and OpenAI built its financial services package with Morgan Stanley and Evercore.** Capital One built its own agent platform under model risk rules (podcast), and OpenAI built ChatGPT for Financial Services with Morgan Stanley and Evercore (OpenAI).
- **Anthropic and OpenAI now reach the rest of the banks through the core banking providers.** FIS made its AML agent, built with an embedded Anthropic team, available to any US bank in October (FIS), Fiserv launched agentOS with OpenAI as a collaborator and an AML triage agent among its four launch agents (Fiserv), and Anthropic's financial services templates include KYC screening, with Citadel, BNY and FIS among its named customers (Anthropic).
- **The FIS agent recommends a decision and leaves each case with the bank's own investigators.** The design partner for the FIS agent says "the investigator remains accountable for the final determination" (FIS).
- **How likely the labs are to absorb this: High.** Through FIS the labs can now reach any US bank with an investigation agent, and their own templates cover KYC screening, though the bank's investigators still own every final determination.

Example companies: Salient, Bretton AI, Gradient Labs

B4. Legal Services

What is happening:

- **Legal work is a big services budget that buyers already pay per matter or per hour to outside firms.** Speakers at a Sequoia event put legal services alone at about $400B in the US (Sequoia event transcript).
- **Anthropic now sells a full legal product and says legal professionals became the most engaged users of its Cowork agent of any knowledge-work function.** Claude for Legal launched in May with 12 practice-area

plugins and more than 20 connectors (Anthropic), and by October Anthropic had added more than 60 legal connectors and a gallery of legal tools built with law firms and PwC (Anthropic).

- **OpenAI followed in September with a legal configuration of its newest model, and its engineers now build custom tools inside several of the biggest law firms.** Astra for Law ships with a legal search index and 26 partner plugins, and OpenAI's forward-deployed engineers built tools for Sullivan & Cromwell, Ropes & Gray and Cooley (OpenAI). OpenAI's own usage research shows weekly active enterprise Codex users in legal grew 108-fold from February, faster than in any other function it reported (Unite.AI).
- **Thomson Reuters built its CoCounsel Legal agent on Anthropic's agent toolkit and also launched a legal model of its own, so the research incumbent now works both with the labs and alongside them.** Anthropic describes CoCounsel Legal as a legal agent built on the Claude Agent SDK (Anthropic), and in August it launched Thomson 1.0, a model trained on its legal research content, while Google expanded Gemini Enterprise for legal professionals (Reuters).
- **How likely the labs are to absorb this: High.** Both labs sell complete legal products, lab engineers build tools inside top law firms and the main research incumbent built its legal agent on a lab toolkit, which makes legal one of the categories where the labs are most competitive.

Example companies: Crosby, Lawhive, EvenUp

B5. Life Sciences Research

What is happening:

- **Drug research is one of the biggest professional budgets in any industry and keeps growing.** R&D spending at the biggest pharma companies rose to $190Bn in 2024 from $163Bn in 2023 (IQVIA Institute).
- **Anthropic sells research products straight to drug companies, and research software stocks fell on the day it launched its research workbench.** Anthropic named Novo Nordisk and Sanofi as customers in January (Anthropic), and Schrodinger shares fell as much as 8.3% the day Anthropic launched Claude Science in June, with Recursion and IQVIA also lower (trade press).
- **OpenAI has its own life sciences model, which left research preview in September and is now sold to drug companies through a vetted access program.** OpenAI launched GPT-Rosalind in April with Amgen and Moderna among its customers and made it generally available to eligible organizations on September 11, alongside a free Codex plugin that connects to more than 50 public databases, literature sources and biology tools (OpenAI).
- **How likely the labs are to absorb this: Medium.** Both labs sell research models and workbenches to named drug companies and investors have already marked down research software stocks, but the products in the sources are tools for each drug company's own scientists rather than research the labs run themselves.

Example companies: Edison Scientific

C. Non-Regulated Verticals

C1. Procurement, Logistics and Distribution

What is happening:

- **Purchasing and freight coordination employ big teams whose work runs on email, portals and phone calls.** Government data counts 491,430 buyers and purchasing agents, 202,810 dispatchers outside emergency services and 97,670 cargo and freight agents (BLS).
- **Oracle now ships 22 agentic applications of its own that act inside the business processes its ERP suite already runs.** Oracle launched its Fusion Agentic Applications in March as teams of specialized agents that run on Fusion data (Oracle).
- **OpenAI is building and testing procurement agents that handle purchasing requests inside a single company, starting with its own finance team.** OpenAI is building a procurement agent with PwC inside its

own finance team (OpenAI) and previewed specialist agents tested on procurement and invoice processing in September (OpenAI).

- **How likely the labs are to absorb this: Low.** The lab work in the sources is a procurement agent inside OpenAI's own finance team and a preview, and Oracle's agents act inside its own ERP, so no lab product yet covers supplier and carrier work that runs across companies.

Example companies: Fragment, Magentic, Didero, InstaLILY, BackOps, HappyRobot, Freehand

C2. Finance and Accounting Operations

What is happening:

- **Finance teams repeat the same work every month with big clerical staffs, and every invoice or reconciliation has a clear count and cost.** Government data counts 1,373,680 bookkeeping, accounting and auditing clerks at a mean wage of $53,560 (BLS).
- **An integrator's automation lead says agents cost several times more to run than the scripted bots finance teams already use.** The automation lead puts a task at $200 or $300 a month on bots and $1,000 or $1,200 a month with AI (expert call).
- **Both labs now go after the in-house monthly close directly, with templates and consulting partners.** Anthropic's spring financial services release includes a month-end closer (Anthropic), and OpenAI and PwC are building agents for planning, payments, tax and the accounting close (OpenAI).
- **How likely the labs are to absorb this: Medium.** Both labs target the in-house close with templates and a Big Four partner, but the sources name no finance team running a lab close agent in production, and agents still cost several times more to run than existing bots.

Example companies: Basis, Niural

C3. Customer Service and Sales

What is happening:

- **Customer service is the first job agents finish end to end at scale, because a resolved ticket is easy to check and to price.** OpenAI says its Presence agent, launched in July, resolves 75% of inbound issues on its own phone line without human assistance (OpenAI), and Salesforce says its agents have handled 4.3 million inquiries on its own help site (CX Today).
- **Salesforce now sells finished service work at a published price, and Microsoft launched an AI layer for contact centers on the systems buyers already run.** Salesforce charges $2 per resolution for its help agent (CX Today), and Microsoft launched Contact Center Intelligence in October on top of existing systems from Cisco and Avaya (Constellation).
- **A Deutsche Telekom executive who leads its choice of customer support AI vendors says OpenAI and Anthropic are largely ruled out there over EU data concerns.** In a July 2026 expert call the executive said the company runs several specialist vendors and plans to cut to one or two once its current contracts end in about 18 months (expert call).
- **How likely the labs are to absorb this: High.** OpenAI, Microsoft and Salesforce already sell finished service work, which makes this the category where the labs and suites are most competitive, with the main limit in the sources being a big telecom that largely rules the labs out over EU data concerns.

Example companies: Sierra, Decagon